

Overcoming Digital Debt and Embracing AI

*Why AI adoption stalls, and
what it really takes to succeed*

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Some of my community activities:

- Weekly interviews on technology, business productivity, and collaboration culture ([#CollabTalk Podcast](#))
- Weekly livestream on project management best-practices ([#ProjectFailureFiles](#))
- Weekly interviews with Microsoft MVPs ([#MVPbuzzChat](#))
- Monthly livestream of the Guardians of M365 Governance ([#GoM365gov](#)) covering all-things governance
- Multiple posts each month with a panel of experts answering community questions ([#M365AMA](#))



The Promise vs. the Reality

- Nearly every enterprise is now investing in AI
- Adoption is at record highs: 88% use AI in at least one function
- But adoption is not the same as value
- Most organizations see no measurable return on the spend
- The gap between buying AI and benefiting from it is widening

95%

of organizations saw zero measurable return from generative AI (MIT NANDA, 2025)

The Hard Truth

Buying AI and benefiting from AI are two completely different things. The license is the easy part.

What Is Digital Debt?

- The inflow of data, emails, meetings, and notifications has outpaced our ability to process it
- Everything feels urgent, so we spend the day just trying to get out of the red
- It accumulates quietly, and the longer it sits, the harder it is to address
- It shows up as lost productivity, higher costs, security risk, and stalled innovation
- It exists at two levels: the organization and the individual

57%

of the average employee's time is spent communicating, not creating (Microsoft)

Satya Nadella

There's an enormous opportunity for AI to help alleviate digital debt, build AI aptitude, and empower employees.

The Individual Cost of Digital Debt



No Focus Time

68% of people say they don't have enough uninterrupted focus time in the workday. Deep work has become the exception, not the rule.



Constant Interruption

The average Microsoft 365 user is interrupted every 2 minutes by a meeting, email, or notification. Focus never gets a chance to form.



The Endless Search

62% struggle with too much time spent searching for information. The answer exists, but finding it is the tax they pay all day.

Digital Debt Costs You Innovation

- Digital debt isn't just an inconvenience. It directly suppresses creative work
- When people can't find time and energy, strategic thinking is the first casualty
- The cost compounds: individual overwhelm becomes an organizational drag
- Leaders feel it too, and they're worried about it
- Every minute spent managing the noise is a minute not spent on what moves the business

3.5x

more likely to struggle with innovation when people lack time and energy (Microsoft)

The Leadership Signal

60% of leaders are already worried about a lack of innovation and breakthrough ideas on their teams.

The Other Half: Organizational Debt



Outdated Technology

Legacy systems slow processes, increase downtime, and drive up maintenance costs. They also can't feed clean data to AI.



Inefficient Processes

Undocumented, workaround-driven processes waste time and create errors. Point AI at a broken process and it just breaks faster.



Untrained People

Without skills and fluency, people can't use the tools they're given. Lack of training is itself a form of debt, and the most fixable one.

Why AI Alone Won't Save You

- The barrier to AI value is people-centric, not technical
- AI accelerates whatever foundation you give it, good or bad
- Tools that don't fit real workflows get quietly rejected
- The organizations that win redesign the work first, then add AI
- AI fluency is the multiplier that turns access into outcomes

2x

more likely to see significant returns when workflows are redesigned first (McKinsey)

The Real Barrier

MIT found the core barrier to scaling AI is not infrastructure, regulation, or talent. It is learning.

01

The Remedy: A Proven Path

Microsoft's recommended adoption framework,
and how to put it to work.

Microsoft's Adoption Framework

- **PLAN:** Gather your team, define goals, pick high-value use cases
- **ENABLE:** Get Copilot into the right hands; complete technical readiness
- **NURTURE:** Build a learning community; train, share prompts, encourage
- **IMPROVE:** Measure usage and impact, run check-ins, celebrate wins
- [My addition] **RINSE, REPEAT:** Because adoption is a cycle, not a one-time launch

4

phases that turn a license purchase into a sustained capability

The Key Shift

Lead with people and process.
Technology is one phase out of four, and not the hardest one.

The People Who Make It Work



Executive Sponsor

A visible leader who connects AI to business priorities and sends the message that this matters. Adoption follows leadership attention.



AI Council

A cross-functional team spanning IT, change management, risk, and the business, guiding strategy, governance, and responsible use.



Champions & Early Adopters

Passionate users who show real benefits in daily work, answer peer questions, and turn enthusiasm into momentum across teams.

Build a Learning Community

- Adoption is a behavior change, and behavior changes socially
- Run lunch-and-learns and town halls that spotlight real, role-specific wins
- Share prompt libraries and curated resources where people already work
- Create a community of practice: a single place to ask, share, and learn
- Celebrate success stories publicly to build momentum and permission

90%+

of workers already use AI tools personally;
channel that energy (MIT)

The Multiplier

Consistent use turns Copilot from a novelty into a natural extension of how people work.

Measure, Then Improve

- Define success metrics before you launch, not after
- Track real usage and adoption with the Copilot Dashboard
- Hold regular check-ins: what's working, what's stuck, what's next
- Set lead metrics for early signals and lag metrics for business impact
- Acknowledge milestones, because momentum needs to be felt to be sustained

66%

of companies struggle to establish ROI metrics for AI; don't be one of them

Why This Matters

A CFO will not accept anecdotes. Define the numbers up front so you can prove the value later.

The Bottom Line

- Digital debt, both individual and organizational, is the real barrier to AI value
- You cannot automate your way out of a foundation problem
- Use the move to AI as the forcing function to finally pay down the debt
- Lead with people and process; let technology follow
- Fluency is the multiplier that separates the 5% from the 95%

5%

create substantial value at scale; deliberate adoption is how you join them

The Takeaway

AI doesn't fix work on its own. It gives you the leverage to redesign work, if you do the human part first.



How I Can Help

- AI literacy workshops: hands-on, practice-heavy sessions for your teams
- Flexible formats from 4 to 16 hours, built around the work your people do
- Microsoft-focused, Google-focused, or fully technology-agnostic tracks
- Strategy and adoption advisory grounded in the framework you just saw
- Microsoft-funded Copilot engagements for eligible organizations

500+ seats?

You may qualify for Microsoft-funded Copilot adoption services

Let's Talk

Reach out at cbuck@collabtalk.com to scope what paying down your digital debt could look like.





Thank You

Questions & Discussion

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